Macdonald-Laurier Institute

Report Part Title: Growing up in a phone-based world

Report Title: WEAPONS OF MASS DISTRACTION
Report Subtitle: Curbing social media addiction and reclaiming the smartphone generation
Report Author(s): Paul W. Bennett
Published by: Macdonald-Laurier Institute (2024)
Stable URL: https://www.jstor.org/stable/resrep61694.4

JSTOR is a not-for-profit service that helps scholars, researchers, and students discover, use, and build upon a wide range of content in a trusted digital archive. We use information technology and tools to increase productivity and facilitate new forms of scholarship. For more information about JSTOR, please contact support@jstor.org.

Your use of the JSTOR archive indicates your acceptance of the Terms & Conditions of Use, available at https://about.jstor.org/terms

Macdonald-Laurier Institute is collaborating with JSTOR to digitize, preserve and extend access to this content.

This content downloaded from 200.89.52.149 on Tue, 31 Mar 2026 23:03:34 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

Growing up in a phone-based world

North America's most widely known "iPhone Baby," Noah Schmick, born in Madison, Wisconsin, on June 29, 2007, is now 17 years old and finishing high school. The white, upper-middle-class teenager who entered this world on the same day the revolutionary first-generation smartphone was launched was made famous two years ago in a video feature produced by Johanna Stern for the *Wall Street Journal* with an alluring title, "The iPhone Generation: An Inside Look at a 15-Year Journey" (Stern 2022). In that short video, we are reminded that Noah and his generation live a life totally immersed in cyberspace. Trying to remember life before the iPhone is next-to-impossible. The vast majority of "iGen" or Generation Z, born after 1995, are the first cohort of what American social critic Jonathan Haidt has aptly termed "phone-based childhood" (Haidt 2024a, 7).

Since the advent of the iPhone, phone-based childhood has come to subsume play-based child rearing with profound implications. Growing up in a phone-based world bred a dependence upon the tiny metal devices and the constant stream of social media. The *Wall Street Journal* video put it best: "Noah's generation is the most extreme example of that dependence because they have never known life without it. It's a generation that fears being disconnected." Just like millions of other families, Apple's invention and a succession of more affordable clone "smartphone" machines made Lauren and Jason Schmick's son and his younger twin sisters "more connected and disconnected in ways that no one anticipated" (Stern 2022). America's foremost expert on generational change, San Diego State University social psychologist Jean M. Twenge goes much further. She claims that changes in technologies affecting childhood – from radio to television to smartphones – contributed to a "mental health crisis" most acutely exemplified in today's adolescents and children (Twenge 2017 and 2023).

This content downloaded from 200.89.52.149 on Tue, 31 Mar 2026 23:03:34 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

Earlier warnings about the potential adverse impact of computer technology on elementary school students went largely unheeded in North American K–12 education. One of the pioneers, Jane M. Healy, registered her deep concerns in two mostly forgotten books, *Endangered Minds*: *Why Children Don't Think and What We Can Do About It* (1987) and *Failure to Connect: How Computers Affect Our Children's Minds – For Better and Worse* (1997). The American educational psychologist challenged the prevailing "techno-optimism" of the mid-1980s, pointing out its adverse effects on young, developing minds, and specifically on critical thinking capacities and reading skills. Dire warnings were later echoed in *Screen Schooled* (2018) by two veteran teachers, Joe Clement and Matt Miles, fierce critics of technology incursions who claimed that technology "overexposure" was "making students dumber" in today's classrooms. None of this really penetrated public consciousness until smartphones proliferated and it became impossible to ignore in school, outside of school, and even in public washrooms.

Canada's smartphone generation is ripe for comparative analysis. Some 5.7 million students were enrolled in our elementary and secondary schools in Canada in 2021–22, about 5.2 million (91.2 percent) of whom attended publicly funded schools (Table 1). Since the advent of the iPhone, an estimated 6.5 million children have been born in our country, from coast to coast (Figure 2). Total public school enrolment actually dipped from 4.9 million in 2006–7 to 4.7 million 2011–12, moved sharply upward from 2014–15 to 2019–20 when COVID-19 hit, and has now recovered to exceed previous levels (Figure 1). Out of an estimated population of 38.9 million in January 2024, some 18.6 percent, or almost 1 in 5 Canadians, might be classified as members of the 'smartphone generation' (Kemp 2024a). Based upon global trends in April 2024, the vast majority of the 16 to 24 age group (over 95 percent) use the internet for social networks and apps for chat and messaging. It is likely that 4 out of 5 internet users (83 percent) in this age group used a search engine like Google in the past month, higher than the 64.1 percent who accessed the most popular social media sites, led by TikTok, YouTube and Snapchat (Kemp 2024b).

Social media penetration is now far more advanced in Canada than it was a decade ago. In January 2015 the global digital monitoring firm, Kepios, reported that 16.2 million Canadians had unique social media accounts, representing 45 percent of the total population (Kemp 2015). Today it is estimated that 31.9

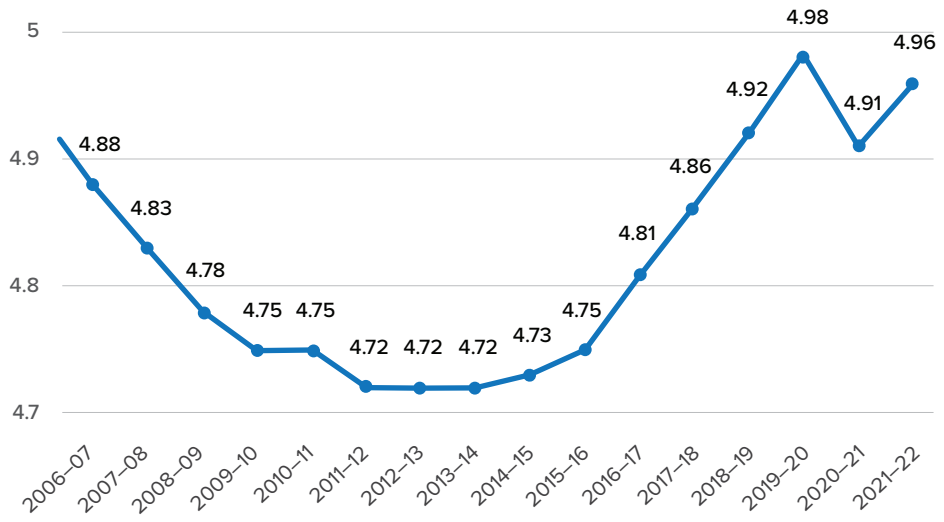
This content downloaded from 200.89.52.149 on Tue, 31 Mar 2026 23:03:34 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

TABLE 1: School population: Elementary and secondary school enrolment, Canada, 2021–2022

School type	Program type	Enrolment (2021–2022)
Public schools	Total	5,230,002 (91.14%)
	Regular programs for youth	4,960,410
	General programs for adults	149.259
	Vocational programs	120,330
Private/independent schools	Total	441,171 (7.68%)
	Regular programs for youth	434,373
	General programs for adults	141
	Vocational programs	6,657
Homeschooling	Total	67,008 (1.17%)
	Regular programs for youth	67,008
	General & Vocational programs	–
All types of schools	Regular programs for youth	5,461,794 (95.18%)
	General programs for adults	149,400
	Vocational programs	126,987
TOTAL	**All types**	**5.738,181 (100.00%)**

Source: Statistics Canada – Table 37-10-0109-01. Release date: 2023-10-12 (Revised with percentages)

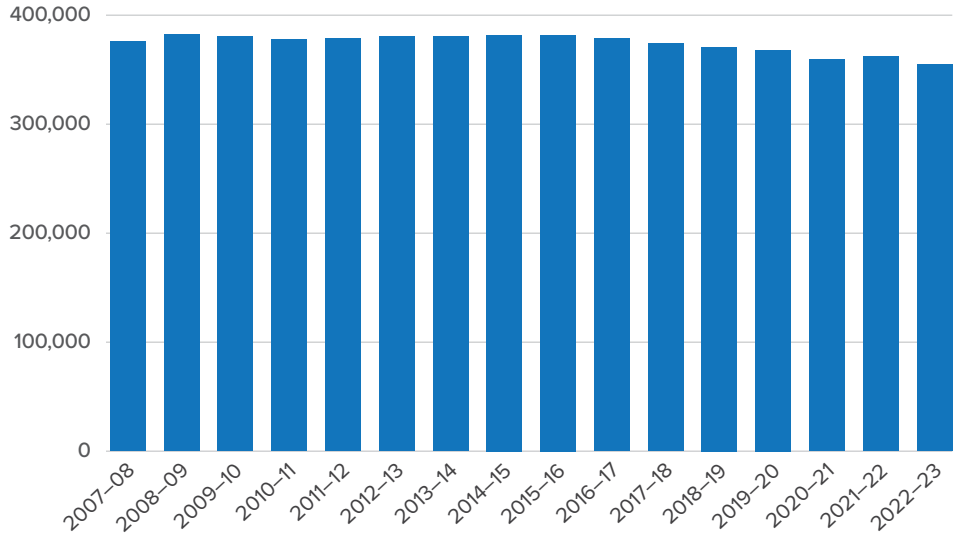
FIGURE 1: Enrolment in public elementary and secondary schools, Canada, 2006 to 2022, millions of students



Source: Statista 2024.

This content downloaded from 200.89.52.149 on Tue, 31 Mar 2026 23:03:34 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

FIGURE 2: The Smartphone Generation – Number of births in Canada from 2006 to 2023



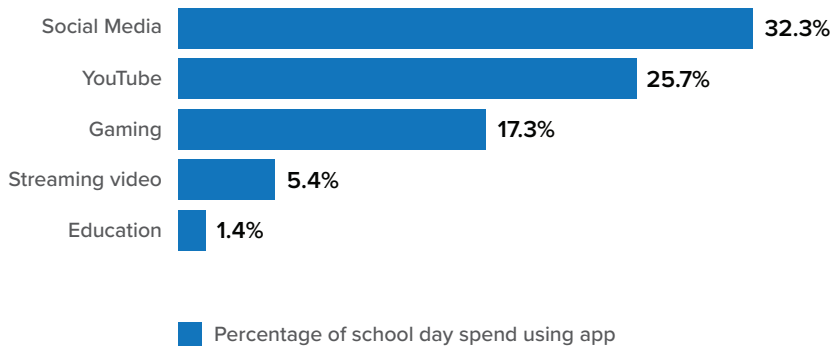
Source: Statista 2024.

million Canadians, or 81.9 percent of the population, are social media users, averaging much higher among school-age children and teens. Young women between 16 and 24, according to global data, spend the greatest amount of time using social media, averaging 3 hours a day (Kemp 2024a). According to American surveys, some 97 percent of students report that they use social media during the school day, but rarely (1.4 percent) for educational purposes (Common Sense Media 2022). Indeed, classroom teachers featured in a recent *Slate* magazine article expressed concerns about a cohort of students "tethered to their home" through devices, communicating constantly by FaceTime and texting with over-protective parents (Shulman 2024).

What happened to Gen Z is now coming into sharper relief. Mobile phones and tablets quickly replaced television as a means of entertaining or 'babysitting' very young children. In 2011, Comon Sense Media surveys found 38 percent of children up to age 8 used mobile devices, but, by 2013, it had jumped to 72 percent (Common Sense Media 2013). One survey of 250 toddlers conducted in October and November of 2014 at a Philadelphia child care centre painted a troubling picture of the pattern in urban, lower-income, and minority communities. Almost all children (96.6 percent) were already

This content downloaded from 200.89.52.149 on Tue, 31 Mar 2026 23:03:34 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

FIGURE 3: Student use of media during classroom time, United States, 2022–23



Source: Radesky, Jenny S. et al. 2023/Common Sense Media

using mobile phones and most started using them before age 1. By ages 3 and 4, researchers reported in *Pediatrics*, that kids were using mobile devices without help, with one-third engaging in activities with applications such as YouTube and Netflix (Fox 2015; McCarthy 2015). Spotting the trend, the American Academy of Pediatrics weighed in, recommending limiting screen time for young children (Brown, Shifrin, and Hill 2015).

The oldest members of this generation born after 1995 began to enter puberty in 2009 when several profound technological shifts converged: the rapid spread of high-speed broadband networks, the invention of the iPhone, and the explosion of hyper-viral and addictive social media (Haidt 2024a, 6). The proliferation of "like" and "share" or "retweet" buttons initially had positive influences and allowed children and teens to "connect" and share experiences with their friends, epitomized in the early iterations of MySpace and Facebook.

Taking selfies with front-facing phone cameras and posting them on social media added to its popularity but exposed a darker side of such platforms. Posting self-images was particularly hard on young girls and led to periodic waves of body-shaming and the circulation of sexually explicit and pornographic images (Haidt 2024a, 6).

Recent analyses such as Haidt's *The Anxious Generation* identify significant changes in the nature and form of childhood associated with the proliferation of mobile devices and the social media explosion. Going through adolescence with a portal in their pocket drew teens away from family and

This content downloaded from 200.89.52.149 on Tue, 31 Mar 2026 23:03:34 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

those nearby and plunged many into the alternative universe of cyberworlds that, while exciting, proved to be addictive, unhealthy, and injurious to their mental health (Bozzola 2022). Increasingly, children and teens turned away from play-based childhood and became totally absorbed in a "phone-based childhood" that was, in the words of Haidt, "hostile to human development" (Haidt 2024a and 2024b).

Social media obsession: teens, tweens, and total dependence

Today's parents and teachers are facing an uphill battle to change the trajectory and reclaim children's minds. Screen time for children in Canada, the United States, and elsewhere spiked during the COVID-19 pandemic from March 2020 until the end of 2021. A Canadian study published in April 2023 *JAMA Pediatrics* found that children's screen time, defined in the study as any screens used for non-school purposes, indicated that youth have become more dependent upon the internet. Based upon a cohort of nearly 1,300 children who were 13 and 14 years old in 2022–23, researchers reported that, at the start of the pandemic, recreational screen time during the week jumped from an average of 1.77 hours to 3.12 hours a day. While that peak subsided, the study found that after lockdowns ended and in-person learning resumed, weekday screen time remained higher with youth (outside of the school day) spending an average of 2.15 hours a day on screens (Plamondon et al. 2023).

Parents on the front lines at home, left on their own, have resorted to extraordinary measures to curb children's and teens' mobile phone use. John Turpin, who lives with his wife and children in Oshawa, Ontario, installed a small safe with a timer in his living room in March 2024 to lock-up the phones of his 14-year-old son and 16-year-old daughter. "We have this discussion regularly about the kind of addiction that it creates," he told the *Globe and Mail*, and about "how it leads you down this road of continuous distraction" (McGinn 2024). Torn between staying in touch with their teens and concern over cellphone addiction, parents are turning to locked

This content downloaded from 200.89.52.149 on Tue, 31 Mar 2026 23:03:34 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms